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The iPod's Achilles' Heel

DAVID CARNOY, EXECUTIVE Editor, CNet Reviews has a few gripes with the (gulp!) Apple iPod. Yes, he managed to find some and now he puts them in black-and-white

Before all the diehard Apple and iPod fans get out their flamethrowers and torch the hell out of me, let me start by saying: I'm with you, the iPod rules, it's great, I own one, I bought one for my wife, and I plan to name my next baby Apple--and not just because Gwyneth Paltrow did. OK, so I'm lying about the baby part, but the rest is true. I like the thing--a lot. But at the same time, it's not totally for me.

First off, I'm pretty lazy when it comes to organizing my music.

Or, more accurately, I just don't have the time to deal with it. Sadly, I recently resorted to having someone else rip the remaining half of my CD collection--about 200 discs--for me. I used a new service called Awaken, which sent me a preaddressed FedEx box. I dumped the discs into the supplied cake boxes and a few days later got back

three DVDs filled with my MP3-ified tunes and all of my CDs neatly organized in a giant binder. Awaken, like several other companies that provide this type of service, charges around \$1 per disc for its deluxe package, which gives you those little extras such as the CD carrying case.

If you have a substantial CD collection, you'll easily end up paying as much for ripping as for the iPod itself. But if you're strapped for time, it's money well spent. But the fact that such services even exist exposes a dirty truth about Apple's little white music player: a lot of iPod owners fail to use their players to their fullest potential. You know the whole line about how we only use a fraction of our brain's power--the same goes for the iPod. I don't have any hard numbers, but I would bet, judging from the informal polling of friends and coworkers, that only about a quarter (or fewer) of iPod users are really getting the most out of their iPods. I meet plenty of people who have 20GB models and only have a couple of gigabytes worth of tunes on them. Their iTunes databases are a mess, they don't make use of playlists, they couldn't care less about podcasts and audiobooks, and they end up listening to the same songs over and over. These are the same people who tend to ask me, "How do I get my friend's collection off his computer onto my iPod?"

The long and short of it is that the iPod is a great device, but it's wasted on a lot of people. As easy as it is to use, it's not for everybody--particularly not for lazy or ultrabusy music lovers who can't afford to impulsively download new albums from the iTunes Music Store at \$10 a pop. (An unnamed CNET vice president reports that he's particularly susceptible to this phenomenon--especially after a few glasses of wine--and that iTunes hangovers are nasty, even for VPs).

Ironically, the biggest chink in the iPod's seemingly impenetrable armor is users' failure to take full advantage of it. And that's exactly why I'd venture to say that ultimately the way for any manufacturer to truly challenge Apple will require both an elegant hardware solution as well as a revolutionary, new music-delivery system. ... (more)

For the complete column go to: <http://snipurl.com/mediawise3>



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